The Observer and the Taste of Presence

JOHN TAN (THUSNESS)

The Observer and the Taste of Presence. By John Tan (Thusness).

© John Tan (Thusness). Free to read and share.

October 2026.

Contents

Preface 5
Note on Method 7
How to Read This Book 11

Part I: The Observer 12
Chapter 1. The Witness Behind Experience 13
Chapter 2. Vividness Without a Viewer 16

Part II: The Logics and the Substrates 20
Chapter 3. Ignorance and Its Habit 21
Chapter 4. Two Logics 25
Chapter 5. The Given 29
Chapter 6. Conceptual All the Way Down? 33
Chapter 7. Energy 35
Chapter 8. Potentiality and Plasticity 37
Chapter 9. Continuity Without a Carrier 39
Chapter 10. The Candle and the Weight of Watching 41

Part III: Two Modes and the Middle Way 43
Chapter 11. Change Without a Changer 44
Chapter 12. The Eight Extremes 46
Chapter 13. Identity, Convention and the Criteria of Truth 48
Chapter 14. Analysis and the Dividing Mind 50
Chapter 15. Reification and Svabhāva as a Way of Seeing 52
Chapter 16. Non-Dividing Seeing 54

Part IV: Beyond Cause and Effect 56
Chapter 17. The Three Assumptions and the Fourth 57
Chapter 18. Spontaneous Presence 61
Chapter 19. Two Traditions, One Risk 64
Chapter 20. The Gap and Its Absence 66
Chapter 21. The Taste of Pacified Reification 68
Chapter 22. Painted Food, Painted Hunger 70
Chapter 23. Recognition, Not Effort 73

Appendices 76
Appendix A. The Verse Text, an Index 77
Appendix B. Glossary 79
Appendix C. The Beginner's Companion, in Eleven Rounds 84
Appendix D. References 86

Preface

Most readers come to this book with a question they have not yet put into words. Sometimes it is a question about the self: who, if anyone, is it that sees and hears and thinks? Sometimes it is about change: what is it that changes when a flame flickers or a life moves on? And sometimes it is about the teaching itself, which says that all phenomena are empty, and which leaves a reader wondering whether the world has been emptied with them.

This book takes those questions seriously and follows them in one direction. It begins with the sense of an observer standing behind experience, and asks whether that observer can be found. It then looks at the substrates that seem to take its place: a given layer beneath concepts, energy as a conserved stuff, a store of possibility behind appearance, a carrier that holds continuity together. Each is examined, and each turns out to be a designation that works, but cannot stand on its own. The argument then turns to the two modes of seeing, dividing and non-dividing, and to the Dzogchen phrase "beyond cause and effect," which the book reads as the point where the question of cause no longer has an object.

The book does not ask the reader to believe any of this in advance. It asks the reader to look, and to notice what the looking finds. The examples are ordinary ones: a chariot in a courtyard, a red patch in the light, a candle burning through the night, a painted rice cake, a meal. The arguments come from Nāgārjuna's *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*, from the Dzogchen and Madhyamaka commentaries that followed it, and from modern physics, psychology and philosophy where they bear on the question.

Two things should be said plainly at the start. The first is that the book is not a survey of the traditions. It follows one line of argument, and it selects the sources that serve that line. The second

is that the reading it offers, which brings Madhyamaka and Dzogchen together around a single appearing seen in two modes, is a synthesis. It is presented as one, and the Note on Method explains what kind of claim it makes. Readers who want the classical positions in their own right are directed to the sources in the references.

The book ends where it begins. The observer is not found. The vividness of experience remains, and it does not need a viewer. What changes is the weight with which experience is held, and the recognition that nothing needs to be produced to take the place of the habit that was seen through.

Note on Method

This book takes a position, and it is important that the reader knows which parts are the author's synthesis and which are the classical material.

The classical material includes the arguments of the *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*, Candrakīrti's reply to Dignāga, Tsongkhapa's account of valid conventions, the Bahiya sutta, and the positions of Mipham, Gorampa and Longchenpa as they are reported in the secondary literature. These are presented as established, and the reader can compare them with the sources.

The synthesis is of eight kinds. The first is the reading of analysis as a response to reification, rather than as a standing activity. The second is the claim that the question "why do appearances spring forth?" is itself a last reification, and that its dissolution is what the Dzogchen phrase "beyond cause and effect" names. The third is the claim that dependent arising and *lhun grub*, spontaneous presence, are not two equal descriptions. Any attempt to divide appearing belongs to dependent arising, and when the reifying habit stops, the same appearing is spontaneous presence. The two traditions converge on this. The fourth is the reading of Dōgen's *Gabyō* through the concept of designation. The fifth is the reading of the two claims (that analysis leaves no foundation, and that appearances arise when conditions align) as one event described in two ways, with the flame as the book's illustrative device. The sixth is the insubstantial reading of self-appearing: the alignment of conditions is the appearing, and the appearing has no owner. The seventh is the three-assumptions framing of Chapter 17, which is the author's scheme and not one that Madhyamaka presents. The eighth, in Chapter 3, is the claim that the seer-seen split is felt in the body as contraction, and that contraction is felt as a self. That claim is

offered for inspection, and readers can test it in their own experience before accepting it. These are the author's own, and they are marked as such where they appear.

The reader should also know that the traditions do not agree on the synthesis. Some Dzogchen lineages hold that the view is its own resultant vehicle, not reducible to Madhyamaka analysis. Gorampa (1429–1489) read the Madhyamaka critique of intrinsic nature more absolutely than Mipham (1846–1912) did. The two never debated: Mipham wrote four centuries later and drew on Gorampa's work. The contrast between their readings is useful because both agree on the danger of reification. The synthesis is that Prāsaṅgika Madhyamaka, as Candrakīrti and Tsongkhapa read it, and Nyingma Dzogchen share the view of appearing set out here. Gelug is a school within Prāsaṅgika, not a third party to the claim. No single tradition has stated this exact formulation, and the claim that the two share a view is the author's synthesis. This book does not decide between Gorampa's and Mipham's readings. It argues that the two traditions converge on undoing the substantialist grasp, and it presents the claim that they share a view of appearing and its emptiness as a reading that can be defended, not as a settled point.

The view itself can be stated in one sentence. It is a rangtong reading of the *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*: everything, mind included, is empty of its own nature (MMK 24.19), and that emptiness is a non-implicative negation, which removes the fixing and puts nothing in its place. On luminous clarity the book follows Nyingma Dzogchen, which takes the *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā* as its view. Luminosity is the knowing clarity of appearing itself (Chapter 2), as empty as everything else. It is never an ultimate that is empty of other things but not of its own nature, as the shentong ("empty of other") reading holds.

The book's position is best described as a Madhyamaka reading of Dzogchen, not as a plain account of Dzogchen's own self-understanding. The reading belongs to a recognised stream in which Dzogchen is read through Madhyamaka, but it departs from

the standard Dzogchen presentation in four places, and the reader should know them before the argument begins.

First, Dzogchen describes a basis (*gzhi*) from which the path and its fruition unfold, and in some systems it speaks of an unproduced primordial purity (*ka dag*). Longchenpa describes the ground as a ground only from a relative perspective, empty of being a ground in the true nature of reality. This book follows that line. It rejects any foundation that appearances are produced from or rest on, and reads *gzhi* as the emptiness of appearing, not as a ground behind it. Where the traditional language of basis is used, the book means this reinterpreted sense.

Second, Dzogchen calls the ground primordially pure and unproduced, which can sound like an uncaused source. This book holds that freedom is not produced and is not a result of causes, but also that it is not an uncaused base. The correction is to the self-description of the tradition, not an interpretation of it, and the book states it as such.

Third, the book uses "openness" in a narrower sense than Dzogchen does. In Dzogchen sources, openness (*stong*, as in *rig stong* and *gsal stong*) is one of the characterisations of the ground, paired with clarity and luminosity, and Longchenpa's ground-awareness is described as an openness that is at once empty and radiant. The book instead treats openness as the way unfixed appearing is seen, not as a property of emptiness or of the ground. Its use of "nature" for emptiness is also narrower than the standard usage of *rang bzhin* and *chos nyid*, which the sources sometimes gloss as intrinsic nature. Readers who know the traditional idiom should take both as deliberate terminological choices, defined in the Glossary.

Fourth, the book's chapter on recognition takes a position on a term that Dzogchen treats as decisive. In Dzogchen, knowledge of the basis comes from recognising it, and recognition (*ngo shes*) is often identified with awakening. The book's chapter title, "Recognition, Not Effort," means only that recognition is not produced by effort or accumulated as a state. It does not deny that

recognition is decisive, and the reader should take the title in that sense.

Some Dzogchen authors, Longchenpa among them, state that the ground is empty and not a subtle existent. The book's reading draws on that statement. It does not claim that this reading is the only one available within Dzogchen.

Terms are used in their standard senses where the tradition has one. Where the book uses a term in a sense of its own, it says so in the Glossary.

How to Read This Book

The book has four parts, and each builds on the one before. Part I looks for the observer and finds vividness without a viewer. Part II begins with the habit that keeps the sense of a substrate alive, examines the logics that produce it, and then the three candidates most often offered for one. Part III turns the analysis on the eight extremes, on identity and convention, and on the two modes of seeing. Part IV takes up the fourth assumption and the Dzogchen phrase "beyond cause and effect," and ends with the taste of pacified reification.

Readers who want the argument straight through can read the chapters in order. Each opens by naming what the previous chapter left unresolved, so the thread is not lost.

Readers who want to test the argument as they go can use the exercises that appear in the text. The chariot, the red patch, the bell, the candle and the meal are all invitations to look. The looking is more useful than the reading, and it is worth stopping to do it.

Readers who want a step-by-step path can follow the Beginner's Companion in Appendix C. Its eleven rounds run alongside the narrative chapters and return to the same examples.

Readers who want the sources can go to the appendices. Appendix A indexes the verses cited in the chapters. Appendix B gives the glossary, which should be read whenever a Dzogchen or Sanskrit term is unfamiliar. Appendix D lists the references. Where a passage depends on a specific translation, the reference names it.

The book is written so that it can be read in a few sittings, but it is not meant to be finished quickly. The argument returns to the same examples from different angles, and each return is meant to be looked at again.

PART I

The Observer

CHAPTER 1

The Witness Behind Experience

It rains. The sound fills the room, and there is no need to be told that something is hearing it. The sound seems to arrive at someone. Behind the eyes, or somewhere just inside the head, there is a point from which the world is taken in and to which every experience appears to belong.

Most people have never questioned this point, because it is not experienced as a belief. It is experienced as the most obvious fact there is. Seeing is someone's seeing. Thinking is someone's thinking. Pain is had by someone, and the pleasure of a cup of tea is enjoyed by someone who sits a little apart from it. This centre has many names: the self, the I, the awareness, the one who knows. Whatever the name, it is pictured as a stable witness standing quietly behind experience, looking out through the senses at a world that is out there.

The witness is so deeply woven into ordinary perception that it rarely comes up for inspection. The question of this first chapter is simple, and it can be asked of anyone. When you look for the witness, what do you find?

Begin with a courtyard. A chariot stands in it. Its wheels are still, its pole is raised, and a horse stamps at the gravel. Ask a passerby what it is, and they will say, without hesitation, that it is a chariot.

Now ask them to show you the chariot. Point to it. Then take it apart. Set the axle aside. Is the chariot gone? No. It is still there, now a chariot without an axle, which is to say a heap of wood that cannot go anywhere. Take away a wheel, the seat, the yoke. At each step the thing you were pointing to has not been found, and yet the word has not stopped being useful. You still know what to do with a chariot, and you know what to do with a heap.

Then ask the last question. Is the chariot the whole arrangement, the parts together? You can look at the arrangement and agree that it is a chariot. But is there a chariot in the arrangement over and above the arrangement? Look for it. You will not find a further thing sitting in the wood, like a seed in a fruit, that makes the wood a chariot.

Nothing has been denied. The chariot is still in the courtyard, the horse still stamps, and the word still works. What has disappeared is an expectation: that there would be a chariot-itself, standing behind the wood and the wheels and making them one thing. The expectation was never met, and the chariot did not need it to be met.

Now turn the same looking on the witness. The observer seems to stand behind the seeing the way the chariot seemed to stand behind the wood. So look for the seer apart from the seeing. Look at a tree. There is a tree, bright in the afternoon light, with its edges and its leaves moving. There is seeing of the tree: the vivid appearance of green and branch. Now look for the one who sees. You will find a tree and a seeing. You will not find a viewer standing apart from both, looking out.

Try the same with sound. The rain is heard. Look for the hearer apart from the hearing. What appears is the rain and the hearing of it, and the sense of a someone who hears them is itself something that appears, a thought or an impression that comes and goes. It is not the hearer. The hearer, looked for as a separate thing, is not there.

This does not mean that nobody is seeing, and it does not mean that a person has disappeared. The tree is seen. The rain is heard. The person who reads this sentence reads it, and that reading is reliable enough to act on. What the looking has shown is narrower. The observer that seemed to stand behind the experience is not found as a separate item. Seeing, hearing and thinking are found, and they are vivid, and they work. The one who sees is not found apart from the seeing.

This is the point at which many readers feel a jolt. Having a witness felt like the ground of experience, and without it there seems to be nothing underneath. The next chapter takes up that feeling directly. For now it is enough to notice that the witness was assumed each time it was looked for, and that the assumption was not confirmed by any appearance.

CHAPTER 2

Vividness Without a Viewer

When the witness is not found, experience does not go blank. This is the first thing the reader needs to see, and it is easy to miss. The habit of looking for a witness often comes with a fear that its absence will leave a void: nothing to see, nothing to hear, a dim unfelt world. The looking shows the opposite. The tree is more vivid, not less. The rain sounds more immediate, not more distant.

What changes is not the vividness. What changes is the architecture. Ordinary experience is arranged as a set of subjects and objects: a viewer and a view, a hearer and a sound, a thinker and a thought. Each object is placed at a distance from the one to whom it appears. Remove the viewer, and the distance goes with it. The sound of rain is no longer the sound that reaches someone. It is simply the radiance of hearing, heard as it is. The warmth of the sun is the immediacy of warmth. Nothing stands at the window and receives these appearances, because nothing was ever standing there. The appearances are not less real for it. They are less mediated.

Think of the colour red. A patch of red is seen in ordinary light. Ask what the red is. It is not the wavelength of the light, which is a quantity measured on instruments. It is not the cone cells in the eye, which respond to the light in ways that can be described. It is not the surface, which reflects the light but has no colour of its own in the dark. It is not the attention that picks it out. And yet the red is not apart from any of these. Change the light and the red changes. Change the eye and it changes. Change the attention and what stands out changes with it.

The same gray looks lighter against a dark surround and darker against a bright one. The redness is not in the gray, and not in the

surround. It appears in a relation among them. This is what dependence looks like when it is seen directly. The red is dependent on its conditions, and it is vivid in itself. It does not need a viewer behind it to be red. It needs the light, the eye, the surround and the seeing, and once they are present it is complete as the appearance it is.

A reader may reasonably ask whether this dependence is itself a kind of inner fact. Does the red depend on the mind, and is the mind then the ground? That question leads back to the witness, and it will be answered more fully in later chapters. For now the reader should see that the dependence is visible in the appearing. The red does not need an argument to be shown dependent. It shows itself that way in the same moment that it shows itself as red.

What, then, is the vividness? The Dzogchen tradition uses the word luminosity for the clarity of an appearance, and the word can be misread. It sounds as if there were a bright substance behind the display, shining through it the way a lamp shines through a window. Looked at carefully, the clarity is not behind the display. It is the knowing clarity of the display itself. A sound is heard as sound. A cold is felt as cold. The knowing and the known are not two things, and the clarity is what the appearance is when it is not being held at a distance. This identification of appearing with its knowing clarity is the book's reading of the luminosity tradition. Chapter 19 sets out the objection it faces.

This matters because it removes the need for a carrier. Every candidate that might be offered as the bearer of vividness, whether a soul, a stream of consciousness, a neural core or a store of potentials, is itself something that appears. It is seen, named, picked out by criteria. So it is designated like everything else, and it would need a carrier of its own. Luminosity is not that kind of object. It is the clarity by which an appearance is known as it appears. The reliability of the appearance is accounted for by its conditions, and its clarity by its own being clear. Nothing further is needed. A reader who tries to say what the clarity requires beyond these will

find that each attempt turns the clarity into a thing, and each thing is again an appearance.

Two consequences follow, and both should be stated plainly. The first is that experience can be vivid and complete without being owned. The second is that experience can end without being taken from anyone. A vivid appearance does not belong to a holder, so nothing is lost when it passes. It passes because its conditions change.

There is one more thing to see before the chapter closes. The vividness of an appearance is not a quality that makes it more real than the dull and the ordinary. A dull grey wall is as vivid as a sunset in the sense that matters here: it appears, it is clear, and it is not found standing apart from its appearing. The difference between them is only a difference in how the mind has been taught to look.

The immediacy this describes has a classical formulation. The Bahiya sutta puts it this way: “In reference to the seen, there will be only the seen. In reference to the heard, only the heard.” The phrase is short and easily misread, and it will return in the last part of the book, where it can be read properly. For now it can be held as a pointer. It names the vividness this chapter has described, with no one standing behind it to receive it.

Once the witness has gone and the vividness is left, a question remains that the first chapter could not settle. If the appearance does not rest on a viewer, what does it rest on? The chariot had no chariot-itself beneath the wood. Does the red, and the rain, and the tree, have a ground beneath them that the viewer was only standing in for? The next part of the book takes that question up in the form it most often takes, which is the search for a substrate.

. . .

The witness was looked for and not found. Vividness was looked at and found without a viewer. What remains is the suspicion that appearance must rest on something beneath it. Part II begins with the habit that keeps that suspicion alive, takes it through the logics that produce it, and then through the three candidates most often offered as the ground: the Given, energy, and a store of possibility.

PART II

The Logics and the Substrates

CHAPTER 3

Ignorance and Its Habit

A reader finishes Part I and agrees with every line. The witness was not found, vividness did not need a viewer, and the argument holds. The next morning someone says something unkind, and within a second there is a someone who was hurt, a someone who now plans a reply. The reader notices this, and the noticing is itself something that appears in the same way. Nothing in the earlier argument was false. It simply did not reach the place where the habit works.

That gap is the subject of this chapter.

Not knowing, and not seeing

Buddhist traditions name the root of suffering ignorance, *avidyā*. The word is easy to misread as a lack of information. A person who has never been told how the planets move is ignorant in that sense, and the remedy is to tell them. The ignorance meant here is different. It is a misrecognition of what is already present. In Dzogchen the term is *ma rigpa*, non-recognition: the nature of appearing is there, and it goes unrecognised. The remedy is not a fact to learn but a seeing that was overlooked. *Ma rigpa* is not a translation of *avidyā*. The two name the same root, the first from the side of what is not recognised and the second from the side of what is not known, and the overlap should not be taken for identity.

This distinction runs through the rest of the book. If ignorance were a missing belief, a good argument could fill it. If ignorance is a habit of not seeing, then argument can only reach a belief about the habit, and the habit carries on working.

The pattern runs before reasoning

The sequence in an ordinary moment is quick, and it is hard to catch because it does not feel like a sequence. Something contacts the senses or the mind. The contact is at once arranged into a seer, a seeing and a seen. A feeling follows: pleasure or pain, attraction or pulling away, a faint tightening or a sense of ease. Then reasoning begins, and it takes the arrangement as the fact it has to deal with. By the time a thought forms, the frame is already in place, and the thought defends it.

Reasoning is not the source. It arrives late and borrows the frame's grammar. This is why people who can argue skilfully against a self can still be wounded by a slight. The argument happened in one place and the wound in another, and the habit that moves between them was never touched.

Why insight does not dislodge it

Here the book has to be honest about itself. Anatta insight can come as a real breakthrough. A reader can see that the one who hears is not found, and feel the relief of it. But very soon the insight starts to be used. "There is no self" becomes something to understand, to hold and to defend, and the one who understands it is the seer again, now standing with a new view. The habit does not object to the new view. It absorbs it.

Analysis works the same way. A reader who examines the self with reasoning is using the same frame to do it. The question "who is looking?" presumes a looker. Each new analysis builds a fresh subject-object relation around whatever it examines, and then treats the result as neutral. The framework does not merely survive the argument. It produces the argument.

This is what the tradition means when it says ignorance is not dissolved by knowledge. Knowledge about ignorance is one more thing known, and the one who knows it is one more seer.

Why logic is needed after all

If insight is not enough and the habit absorbs reasoning, why go on to logic at all? Because the habit is most persuasive when nothing challenges it. An argument that shows how the frame is assumed, rather than found, gives the seeing something to rest on when the feelings are strong. The logics in the next chapter do not replace the seeing. They help keep it steady while the habit tries to take it back.

That is also why the logics have to be shown using the same words as the habit, while beginning from somewhere else. Chapter 4 takes that up.

The felt side of the habit

The structuring is not only conceptual. Consider what goes with the sense that someone has been hurt. The chest may tighten. Breath shortens. Attention narrows to a point and draws in. The world feels further off, and the self feels more solid and more in need of protection or repair. When the frame loosens, the same body may soften, the breath lengthen, the attention open.

The chapter offers a claim about experience for inspection: the seer-seen split is felt as contraction, and contraction is felt as a self. Readers can test this in their own experience without accepting it first. In a moment of irritation or loss, notice whether the sense of being wronged arrives with a particular tightening, and whether that tightening eases when the sense of someone being wronged is not taken as a fact. This is an introspective observation, not a controlled finding, and it should be tested before it is believed.

What the habit is made of

The habit rests on at least four supports, and each can be looked at directly.

Grammar. Language gives the subject-predicate form, which places a stable doer behind every act. The section “Do we actually think substantially?” in Chapter 4, Two Logics, shows how far this

reaches. It is not a theory anyone chose, and it is not removed by saying that everything changes.

Memory. The self is assembled from remembered episodes, and the remembering is treated as proof that a rememberer exists. But the remembering appears as an event, like the sound of rain, and it can be looked at in the same way.

Naming. A name is attached to a stream of experience and then given the job of standing for a continuing holder. The name is useful. It is a designation, not a holder.

The need for a ground. This may be the deepest support. Uncertainty feels like falling, and so a floor is looked for beneath experience. That wish is what the later chapters trace through the substrates. It is also what makes the habit feel like a necessity rather than a choice.

Seeing the pattern, not fighting it

The practical conclusion is that the first step is to see the pattern as a pattern. The aim is not to replace it with a better picture, and it is not to suppress the feelings that arrive with it. A new positive account of "the true nature" beneath the seer would only build a second seer. Madhyamaka's distinction between a negation that installs nothing and one that installs a replacement is the guide here. The pattern is seen as something added, and the adding is noticed without a substitute put in its place.

Seeing the pattern can be brief. A thought of "I" arises, and it is noticed as a thought. A feeling of being wronged arises, and it is noticed as tightness, heat, narrowing. Nothing is done to it. The looking is enough to show that the seer was not standing where the habit said it stood.

CHAPTER 4

Two Logics

Watch a candle burn for a minute. The flame leans, steadies, shrinks when the door opens, and recovers. Ask what is happening, and the answer arrives before any thought: the flame is changing. Something is there, and something is happening to it.

Even after the arguments of Part I have been followed and accepted, this picture tends to return the moment attention is off duty. One still sees a something undergoing change. The persistence of that picture is the subject of this chapter. It is not a stray belief that a counter-argument can remove. It is a way of reasoning. Call it the logic of substance. It starts with things and then asks what happens to them. Do they arise, last, move, end, stay the same?

The analysis of this book starts one step earlier. It does not begin with things. It asks how anything is identified as a thing in the first place, and it finds that it is identified only in dependence: on parts, causes, contrasts and the designation under which it is picked out. No thing stands there before that identification. Call this the logic of dependency. The two logics use the same words, change, cause, identity, continuity and the path. But because they begin in different places, the same words lead them into different worlds.

Do we actually think substantially?

Before the two logics can be compared, an honest question must be faced. Does anyone actually reason in the substantialist way? Ask people whether things have fixed essences and most will say no. Everything changes, they will say. Everything is connected. Nothing lasts. Many have read enough to call themselves process thinkers. If the logic of substance is a position nobody holds, this chapter is arguing with a ghost.

The test is not what people say when asked, but what they do when they are not asked. Three places show it.

In space. Asked, few people will say that space is a thing. Yet almost everyone pictures it as one: a vast, empty room in which objects are placed, which would remain if every star were removed. Newton wrote the intuition into physics, holding that absolute space stays always the same, without relation to anything outside it. The picture shapes casual speech: there is room for a sofa, nothing between the stars. What is never met is space apart from distance and reach. The room that would survive the removal of everything is not found. It is assumed.

In time. Time is held more tightly still. It is pictured as a river flowing on its own, carrying events whether or not anything happens. Language treats time as a substance in two ways at once. It is a moving thing: the deadline approaches, the years went by. And it is a stuff: we spend it, save it, and run out of it, the pattern Lakoff and Johnson called "time is money". Cultures differ in the shape of the picture, and speakers of Aymara, Núñez and Sweetser found, place the past in front and the future behind. But the substance remains: a time that is somewhere, apart from the events placed in it. The general anaesthetic of Chapter 10 is the plain counter-evidence. Three hours pass on the clock and none in experience. No river was found that flowed by itself.

In grammar. Every sentence about change has a subject and a predicate. The flame flickers, the market falls, I have changed. The subject is held still so that the predicate can happen to it. This is not a theory anyone chose. It is the shape a thought takes before it becomes a thought. Saying that everything changes does not escape it, since "everything" becomes the subject and is still pictured as the thing doing the changing.

The answer, then, is yes, but with a qualification that matters. We do not think substantially all the time. Much of practical life already runs on relations. A cook judges dough by how it responds, not by its essence. A driver reads the traffic, not the cars in themselves. The habit is a default that switches on at particular places: when we

explain and when we name. Those are the places where the logic of substance does its work, and they are where the logic of dependency has to be tested.

What "logic" means here

"Logic" has a precise sense in this book, and it is easy to hear it in another. It does not mean that Madhyamaka has a special logic of its own, and it does not mean that emptiness is reached by going beyond logic. It means the necessity of a consequence. Whoever proposes that something exists from its own side must say what it is. To say what it is, they must pick it out by contrast and designation, and so make it dependent. The argument borrows its premises from the opponent and shows that they cannot be stated without undermining themselves.

Three features follow. The logic is not inductive: it does not survey the world and report that no essences have turned up. It shows what anyone proposing an exception must already be doing. Its conclusion is a negation without a thesis, a negation that removes inherent existence and installs nothing in its place. And it does not break the ordinary rules of reasoning. It relies on non-contradiction throughout. The chariot cannot be both identical with its parts and different from them. Fire cannot be both one with its fuel and other than it. The analysis has its force because it holds the opponent to exactly these rules.

What, then, of the famous refusals: neither existent nor non-existent, neither arising nor ceasing? These are not contradictions, and they do not suspend the law of excluded middle. They refuse a presupposition. "Is the present king of France bald?" cannot be answered yes or no, because there is no present king of France. The question fails before either answer could be true. "Does the self exist, or not?" and "Does this moment arise or cease?" fail in the same way. Each presupposes a bearer with a status of its own. When no such bearer is found, both answers fall together. Logic has not been suspended. The question had nothing to be about.

This is the difference between the Middle Way and its imitations. A view that claims to transcend logic can say anything, and so says nothing. The logic of dependency says one thing exactly: what is proposed as standing on its own is not found to do so, and the proposal undermines itself.

CHAPTER 5

The Given

If there is no observer standing behind experience, the next question is whether appearance rests on something beneath it: some undesignated layer that is simply there, which concepts then describe. Philosophers have called this the Given. The idea has a long history in the West and an older, more rigorous one in Buddhist epistemology.

Begin with Locke. He divided qualities into primary ones, such as shape and motion, which belong to bodies themselves, and secondary ones, such as colour and warmth, which are only powers in bodies to produce sensations in us. The primary qualities were the bedrock. Wilfrid Sellars later attacked the whole structure from inside empiricism, arguing that the idea of a pure given in experience is a myth: what we call a sensation is already conceptual.

Buddhist philosophy had worked out its own version of the Given centuries earlier, and with greater rigour. Dignāga, in the *Pramāṇasamuccaya*, opens with a symmetry. There are exactly two means of valid knowledge, perception and inference, because there are exactly two kinds of object. The particular, what characterises itself alone, is grasped by perception. The universal, a general character shared by many things, is grasped by inference and concept. Perception itself is defined as free from conceptual construction.

Dharmakīrti sharpened the scheme. Perception is free from construction and non-erroneous. What makes the particular ultimately real is that it alone can do something: it is capable of causal efficacy. Universals do nothing. The fire that is merely thought of burns no one.

The result is a two-storey epistemology. On the lower floor are momentary, efficacious particulars, touched by perception before any concept arrives. On the upper floor are concepts, which never touch particulars at all. They construct general characters by exclusion, so that "cow" means what is not non-cow, and they are useful precisely because, strictly speaking, they misrepresent what they seem to present.

This position should not be caricatured. Dharmakīrti does not posit a bare substance waiting beneath qualities. He rejects the split between substance and property altogether. His claim is subtler: the real is what functions, and what functions is met by perception before designation. That is why it is the strongest form of the Given. It is a Given without a substrate, built by philosophers who had already accepted momentariness and dependent arising. If any account could keep an undesignated layer while honouring everything else this book has argued, it would be this one.

Candrakīrti's reply

In the first chapter of his commentary on the *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*, Candrakīrti answers a view closely resembling Dignāga's. Three of his moves bear directly on the Given.

The first concerns the word own-characteristic itself. A characteristic is the characteristic of something: hardness characterises earth. Is the characteristic different from what it characterises? Then earth, apart from its hardness, has no characteristic, and nothing has been picked out. Is it the same? Then nothing characterises anything, and "own-characteristic" says nothing. This is the analysis Nāgārjuna applied to space. Characteristic and characterised are designated together, and neither is found first. A particular singled out as "this, characterised by itself alone" has already been singled out by contrast, which is the very operation the two-storey scheme reserved for the upper floor.

The second move concerns what perception is of. Candrakīrti does not abolish perception. He accepts it as a means of knowledge, together with inference, testimony and analogy, as the world uses them. But what the world perceives is the pot, not a momentary patch of colour. The object of perception is already a designated whole, met as a pot from the start, in the way a cup on a table is seen as a cup.

The third move comes from Nāgārjuna. Means of knowledge and objects of knowledge, he argues, are not established by themselves. Each is established only in relation to the other. Dignāga's founding symmetry, two means because two objects, is therefore not a foundation. It is co-definition, like long and short.

Tsongkhapa makes the conclusion explicit and makes it a defining mark of the Prāsaṅgika view. Nothing is established by its own characteristic, not even conventionally. Other Buddhist schools refuted the particular's ultimate status and kept it conventionally. Prāsaṅgika refuses it at every level.

What is kept, and what goes

The refusal is narrow. Valid cognition is kept. Perception is still distinguished from inference, a snake in a rope is still corrected by a lamp, and Tsongkhapa's criteria still sort sound conventions from mistaken ones. What goes is only the claim that perception's object is there from its own side, before designation, as the floor beneath it.

Dharmakīrti's deepest reason for that floor was efficacy. *Substrateless World* answers it. The key's power to open is found only together with the lock, the hand and the door. Causal efficacy is itself a relation. The mark that Dharmakīrti took for the stamp of independent reality turns out to be the clearest mark of dependence.

When the particular is not found, the two-storey building has no ground floor. Perception is not a lower layer, and concept is not a

top coat. Vividness and designation are mingled through and through.

CHAPTER 6

Conceptual All the Way Down?

If there is no Given, the opposite conclusion beckons. Perhaps experience is concept through and through, and the world is simply what our concepts make of it.

The most careful modern form of this thought is John McDowell's. In *Mind and World* he argued that conceptual capacities are already at work in perceptual experience itself, which is how experience can give us reasons. The conceptual, he wrote, is unbounded. There is no outer edge beyond which a non-conceptual given waits. Readers often summarise the view as "conceptual all the way down", though that is a gloss rather than McDowell's own wording.

Hubert Dreyfus objected that this cannot be right of skilled, absorbed activity. The chess master who sees the move, and the expert who simply copes, are not applying concepts at all. McDowell's reply is one of the most instructive exchanges of recent philosophy.

The Madhyamaka sides with neither. McDowell is no idealist. He insists the world constrains what we think. But a mind whose concepts reach everywhere, read as an account of what reality is, has replaced the substance of the realist with the concept of the idealist. *Substrateless World* met this move in the form of idealism, panpsychism and Mind-Only. Dreyfus's absorbed coping, read in the same way, restores a pre-conceptual floor. The Given reappears in practical rather than perceptual dress. Each makes one term prior.

What the analysis keeps is a symmetry, in two parts.

- **Appearance is not raw material for concepts.** The ice stings with its own sharpness, and no one decides the sting. A shadow

cannot be designated a bridge. The constraint that keeps designation from being arbitrary comes from the vividness itself.

- **Concepts are not a veil over appearance.** The cup is seen as a cup, and the duck as a duck. Designation is not a screen held in front of the world. It is in the appearing.

Neither is the ground of the other. Concepts draw their content and their correction from what appears, and what appears is picked out and made usable through designation. They are designated together, like long and short. Even the words "conceptual" and "non-conceptual" are co-defined, each identified only as the other's contrast.

Dreyfus's own examples show this. Riding a bicycle is not a set of rules stored in the head, and it is not a wordless reflex beneath all rules. The skill is designated together with rider, machine, slope and wind, and found in none of them alone. And designation is wider than language. "Conceptual all the way down" mistakes designation for a kind of sentence. "Non-conceptual at bottom" mistakes the absence of words for the absence of designation.

The ordinary distinction survives. Seeing a snake is not remembering one, and a perception can correct a thought, as the lamp corrects the rope. Dharmakīrti's line between perception and conception keeps its conventional use. What it loses is the claim to mark two natures, one beneath the other.

So the answer to the objection is neither "conceptual all the way down" nor "non-conceptual at the bottom". There is no down.

CHAPTER 7

Energy

A reader trained in physics may feel that a carrier has been found after all. Energy is conserved. It changes form, chemical into heat, heat into motion, mass into light, while the total stays the same. Surely energy is the something that persists through every change: the modern successor to substance.

Physics itself does not treat it so. Energy is not a fluid poured from one container into another. It is a quantity, a number computed in different ways for different forms, whose total for a closed system comes out the same before and after. Richard Feynman made the point in his lectures: physics has no picture of energy as blobs of anything, only a calculation that keeps balancing.

Three further facts confirm that energy is no substrate. Its amount depends on the frame of reference. A moving ball has kinetic energy relative to the ground and none relative to a runner keeping pace with it, so no amount belongs to the ball by itself. Its conservation follows, by Noether's theorem, from a symmetry: the laws of physics do not change over time. It is a feature of how regularities hang together, not a store of stuff. And in an expanding universe, where light is stretched and loses energy, there is no well-defined total that is conserved at all. A true substance could not simply fail to add up.

From the side of this book, "where did the energy come from, and where did it go?" is the extreme of coming and going asked of a number. When a match burns, chemical energy becomes heat and light. The sentence is correct, and the regularity it records is among the most reliable conventions there are. But nothing is found leaving the match head and travelling into the flame. Conservation

is a designated regularity of the highest reliability. It is not a passenger.

CHAPTER 8

Potentiality and Plasticity

A subtler candidate remains. If nothing is fixed from its own side, appearances seem endlessly malleable. The same dress is seen as white and gold or as blue and black. The same lines are seen as a duck or a rabbit. The same electron appears as a particle or a wave depending on how it is asked. Surely, then, there is a store of potentialities from which these appearances are drawn: Aristotle's potency, Heisenberg's potentia, the abstract space of possibilities that quantum theory describes. Appearances would be the actualisations, and the potentialities what is really there.

This is the move that *Substrateless World*, in its treatment of quantum measurement, calls a substrate for emptiness. Seeing that phenomena have no fixed nature, the substantialist mind gives their openness a home behind them, and so turns emptiness into a new substance, one made of possibilities instead of stuff.

But a potential is identified only through its actualisation and its partner. Salt is soluble only in relation to water. A seed is a seed only in relation to the sprout. "Could" is a designation made within a framework of conditions, not a thing waiting backstage. When Nāgārjuna says that for whom emptiness is possible, everything is possible, the verb means "fits" or "works". It does not describe a reservoir.

Nor is the plasticity infinite. Appearances are open because they depend, and constrained for the same reason. A rope can appear as a snake in dim light. A shadow cannot be walked across as a bridge. The dress divided its viewers into two colourings, not into every colour at once. A plasticity independent of conditions would itself be a kind of own-nature, a power able to make anything from its own side. That is the idealist extreme, not the Middle Way.

Appearances are exactly as plastic as their conditions allow, and no more.

The Dzogchen word *ma 'gags pa*, unobstructed, fits better than "potential". Nothing blocks the display, and there is no store behind it from which the display comes.

CHAPTER 9

Continuity Without a Carrier

If there is no carrier, what makes a life one life, a habit one habit, a river one river? The logic of substance has only one answer: something persists. A soul, a stream of consciousness, a neural core, or the energy that is conserved: each is proposed as what carries continuity through time. Remove it, the substantialist expects, and what is left is a series of disconnected flashes, each moment sealed off from the next.

The logic of dependency rejects both pictures, the carrier and the disconnection. Nāgasena's lamp is the classic image. The flame of the last watch of the night is neither the flame of the first watch nor a different flame. Nothing passes from one to the next, and yet the second is not unconnected with the first. Continuity is designated on a succession that is neither identical nor wholly different.

A melody known by heart shows how this works. Each playing is new, and none is the previous one. There is no tune stored somewhere between playings, waiting to be released. Yet the tune is recognised across them all, and it can be played well or badly, remembered or forgotten, changed by practice. Habit, character, skill and karma are like this. Each moment is conditioned by what went before, and the link is real and reliable. But the link is designated across the moments, not carried by something that runs through them.

Two consequences follow. The first is that nothing is lost. Memory, responsibility, learning and the karmic continuity the tradition describes are all preserved, as designations that hold. The second is that nothing is fixed. A continuity not carried by an essence can bend. A habit can loosen, a character can soften, a grievance can end, because there was never anything underneath

that had to stay the same. Continuity without a carrier is more reliable than the nihilist expects, and more open than the substantialist can allow.

CHAPTER 10

The Candle and the Weight of Watching

Under general anaesthesia three hours pass on the clock, and none in experience. No river of time flowed by itself, carrying an unconscious passenger. On waking, the familiar self is put together again: fully functional, and nowhere to be found as a standing spectator. The continuity was not a thing that persisted through the sleep. It was designated, on waking, across the gap in experience.

This is the first thing the death chapter asks the reader to see. The fear of death is not only a fear of pain, or of leaving people behind, though those are real. It is the fear that a particular experience, the taste of this afternoon and the light in this room, will be lost, and lost to someone who has been holding it. The fear presupposes two things: that experience is a possession, and that a possessor stands behind it who can be deprived. Remove the possessor and the second half of the fear has no subject. Remove the possession and the first half has no object.

Dōgen gives the image of firewood and ash. Firewood becomes ash, and the ash cannot return to being firewood. Yet, Dōgen says, we should not regard the ash as after and the firewood as before. Each abides fully in its own position. Life does not become death, as winter does not become spring. The image removes the sense of a sequence in which one thing is lost to make way for the next.

The dread of death, in its most common form, presupposes that the vividness of experience was inherent, and that it will be taken away with the self. Remove the presupposition and the dread loses its object. The view does not promise that anything of the person continues as the person. It does not claim a carrier after all. It does not make the loss of someone we love painless. What it removes is

one particular dread: the image of an experience that is held, a holder who is taken away, and a holding left unfinished.

In its place the view offers a different relation to the present. Because nothing is being held, nothing is deferred. The value of this moment does not depend on how many moments come after it, since no moment was ever a container for the rest. Attention need not hurry toward a future it cannot have, or cling backward to a past it cannot keep. The luminosity of this appearance, its clarity, its colour and the sound in the next room, is available now, including to the one who is dying. That availability was never conditional on a long life.

The candle gives exactly as much light as before. Nothing is taken from it by going out, and the room is not darker for the flame's giving. What changes is the weight with which it is watched.

For the person who thought they had a self to lose, the burning down was a countdown to catastrophe. Once the self is seen as designated, the same burning is watched differently. It is not a loss suffered by a holder. It is the fact of appearance, undivided, lit and passing. The light was never something the candle owned, so its dimming does not subtract from anyone.

The view asks nothing of the dying about what comes after. It asks them to see that the thing they were holding was never a thing, and that what remains, the vividness of this moment, has never needed a bearer to be complete.

. . .

The logic of substance keeps returning, and it returns through the three candidates for a ground: the Given, energy, and potentiality. Each has been shown to be a designation that works but cannot stand on its own. Continuity, too, was shown to need no carrier. What remains is the question of how the mind divides appearance in the first place, and what the analysis of that division can and cannot do. Part III takes up the eight extremes and the two modes of seeing.

PART III

Two Modes and the Middle Way

CHAPTER 11

Change Without a Changer

The logic of substance pictures change as a noun with verbs happening to it. There is a flame, and the flame flickers. There is a person, and the person ages. There is water, and the water freezes. The noun is the stable carrier. The verbs are what befall it. The question "what really changed?" looks for the carrier underneath.

Look for the carrier. The flame at this moment is wax vapour, oxygen and light that were not there a moment ago and will be gone the next. Nothing in the flame is the flame across the minute. Take away the burning and no flame is left over to have been burning. The noun is never found apart from the verbs.

Yet the verbs are not found apart from the noun either. A flickering with nothing flickering is no more available than a flame that does not flicker. Nāgārjuna makes the point with walking. The walker and the walking are designated together, and neither is found first. The same holds for changer and change. Each needs the other to be named, and neither is a thing waiting behind the naming.

This is why the habitual picture is so hard to set down. It is not a belief about flames. It is the grammar of a sentence, subject and then predicate, laid over experience and taken for the shape of the world. The logic of dependency does not replace the subject with a better subject, such as a process, a flow or an energy. It notices that subject and predicate, changer and change, are designated together within a framework of before and after, and that the framework does not stand on its own.

What remains is change met without a thing that changes. The candle still burns down. The wax is shorter at midnight than at dusk, and one can say correctly when it was lit and when it went

out. Nothing is lost from the burning. Only the passenger is let go: the something that was supposed to ride along underneath, staying the same while everything about it differed.

The test is available at once. The next time the picture of something changing arises, look for the something. Not in theory, but in what is in front of you: the sound that is fading, the thought that is passing, the flame that is leaning. Look for what is changing, apart from the changing. The picture insists it must be there. The looking finds more change, vivid and exact, and no changer behind it.

CHAPTER 12

The Eight Extremes

Nāgārjuna's homage names eight extremes in four pairs: arising and ceasing, permanence and annihilation, coming and going, identity and difference. Under the logic of substance these are simply the questions one asks about anything. When did it start? When will it end? Does it last, or is it destroyed? Where did it come from, and where did it go? Is it the same as that, or different?

Each of these questions assumes the same thing: that there is something with whereabouts, a position in time, space or identity that belongs to it from its own side. Arising and ceasing place it at the two ends of a line. Permanence keeps it on the line, and annihilation removes it. Coming and going move it from one place to another. Identity and difference set it beside something else to be compared. The extremes are not eight separate errors. They are eight ways of asking where a thing is.

The logic of dependency does not answer these questions in a subtler way. It turns them over. It does not say that the thing arises in a hidden form, lasts beneath the change, or goes somewhere invisible. It says that what was supposed to have whereabouts is not found, and so the questions lose their object.

Extreme	The substantialist question	What dependency finds
Arising	When did it come into being?	No thing crossing an edge from absent to present. "It began at noon" holds as convention
Ceasing	When did it go out of being?	No thing falling into nothing. Ending is designated within before and after
Permanence	What stays the same underneath?	No carrier beneath the change

Extreme	The substantialist question	What dependency finds
Annihilation	What was destroyed?	Nothing that stood on its own to be destroyed
Coming	Where did it come from?	No whereabouts before it appeared
Going	Where did it go?	No whereabouts after. The question does not apply
Identity	Is it the same as that?	Not identical: the sprout is not the seed
Difference	Is it something else entirely?	Not wholly other: rice yields rice

The decisive point is easy to miss. Dependent arising is not one thing and the eight negations another, as if what arises in dependence were then also, mysteriously, free of arising. The negations describe dependent arising itself. If a sprout could be found arising from its seed, it would have an arising of its own, and it would not need to depend. That it depends is exactly why no arising is found when it is sought. Dependence and unfindability are one fact, seen from the side of convention and from the side of analysis.

This turns ordinary experience upside down without removing any of it. Switch off a lamp, and the room is dark, and the light went nowhere. Switch it on, and the room fills, and the light came from nowhere. Both descriptions hold of every appearance, and both were true all along.

CHAPTER 13

Identity, Convention and the Criteria of Truth

Under the logic of substance, "what is it?" and "is it the same?" have answers hidden in the thing itself. A thing is what its essence makes it, and it remains the same thing as long as the essence remains. The questions may be hard, but they are factual. Somewhere in the thing, the answer is waiting to be found.

The logic of dependency moves the question. Identity is not what a thing is in itself. It is how the thing is reliably picked out. "Is it the same?" becomes "the same by which criteria, for which purpose, within which framework?" The phone with the cracked screen is the same phone for the repair shop and for the insurer. A ship whose every plank has been replaced is the same ship on the register, and perhaps not for the museum that kept the old planks. The child in an old photograph is you for your family, for your birth certificate, and for the story that runs from that afternoon to this one. Each answer is correct within its framework. None of them is found in the thing apart from the framework.

This does not make identity arbitrary. Criteria can be applied correctly or incorrectly, and they are tested against further experience. A forged passport fails. A mistaken identification in a crowd is corrected when the face turns. What has gone is only the further claim that beneath the criteria there is an identity they are trying to track: a sameness from the thing's own side, which the criteria merely detect.

For many readers this is the point at which the analysis stops being abstract. Identity seemed the most undeniable thing there was: I am I, this is this. Seen through the logic of dependency, it is

not less real. Its reality is of a different kind. It is the reality of a designation that works.

The same shift changes the meaning of "conventional". The logic of substance hears the word as a demotion. Whatever is conventional is agreed on, perhaps arbitrary, certainly less than real. The real is what would be there whether or not anyone agreed, and the path must lead from the conventional to something truer behind it.

For the logic of dependency, conventional truth is the only kind of validity there is, and it is fully valid. It has standards. Tsongkhapa's three criteria sort sound conventions from mistaken ones. A valid convention is known to a conventional consciousness, is not contradicted by any other conventional cognition within that convention, and is not contradicted by reasoning that analyses whether something intrinsically exists. The snake in the rope fails the second test: a lamp shows it is a rope. The rope taken as inherently existing fails the third. The rope as designated passes all three. Convention is not the opposite of truth. It is where truth, in every usable sense, lives.

What changes is the status of the undeniable. Under substance, certain things seem beyond question: that this table is simply here, that I am simply me, that time simply flows. They are felt not as conventions but as facts that convention merely reports. The logic of dependency shows each of them to be a designation so reliable and so habitual that its being a designation has become invisible. Nothing of its reliability is lost when this is seen. Only its claim to stand outside the framework that makes it reliable is lost.

There is no second, deeper truth for convention to fall short of. Ultimate truth is not a higher world. It is the emptiness of this one: the fact that the conventional table, the conventional self and the conventional hour are not found from their own side. There is one appearance, seen two ways.

CHAPTER 14

Analysis and the Dividing Mind

Cognition divides. It takes a whole, separates it into parts, names the parts, and asks which part carries the identity of the whole. A cup becomes a handle, a rim and a body. Motion becomes a before and an after. This is conceptual construction, the mode of mind that the Buddhist traditions call *vikalpa* or *kalpanā*.

Analysis is the MMK's answer to this habit. It takes motion, fire and fuel, agent and action, and the conditioned, divides each into parts, relations and origins, and shows that none of the divisions yields what was claimed. The chariot is not in the wheels, the axle or the pole. Motion is not in the mover or the moved. The analysis works by using the dividing mind against itself.

Analysis has two faces. Conceptually, it separates an object into components and searches for the one that carries identity. Perceptually, the same division is already built into experience. We see a cup as parts because we have learned to. The MMK's claim is that this partitioning is not a neutral description of what is there. It is a mode of cognition that treats the parts as the real basis of appearance and the whole as an aggregate that needs explaining.

The regress makes the mode visible. Each part can be divided again, and the search for an indivisible basis either never ends or ends in a part that cannot be found when examined. Nāgārjuna does not conclude that conventional objects are unreal. He concludes that the analysis cannot find the intrinsic nature it presupposes. The parts, too, are designated.

This is why the MMK uses analysis to expose analysis. It does not abandon the dividing mind. It shows that the dividing mind is a formation, and not a discovery.

MMK 24.18 names the middle way in these terms. Whatever is dependent co-arising, that is what we call emptiness. That, being dependent designation, is the middle way. The verse holds three things together. Dependent arising is the fact that things come from causes and conditions. Emptiness is the lack of intrinsic nature that follows from that fact. Designation is the way such things are named and known, and the naming is itself dependent. Dependent designation is therefore not a compromise between existence and non-existence. It is what the middle path looks like when it is understood.

The verse blocks two errors at once. Eternalism treats things as having a fixed, self-standing nature that persists regardless of conditions. Nihilism concludes from the absence of intrinsic nature that nothing exists. Designation avoids both. Things are not nothing, because they function and can be named. They are not self-existent, because their designation depends on causes, parts and the mind that names them.

The logic runs in one direction. Whatever arises dependently arises from causes and conditions. Something with intrinsic nature would not need to depend on anything, because its nature would be self-sufficient. So whatever arises dependently lacks intrinsic nature, and that lack is what “empty” means. Emptiness is therefore not a separate reality behind phenomena. It is what dependent arising amounts to when its ontological status is examined. There is not one phenomenon that has not arisen dependently, and so there is not one phenomenon that is not empty.

CHAPTER 15

Reification and Svabhāva as a Way of Seeing

Where does a ground come from? Not from the appearances themselves, which are many, particular and relational. It comes from a two-step operation.

First, a common feature is abstracted from the particulars. The sameness of "chariot" across many assemblies of parts, or of "presence" across many experiences, is drawn out. The abstraction is useful. Language, memory and conventional life depend on it.

Second, the abstraction is reified. It is taken to exist as a thing in its own right, standing beneath the particulars and grounding them. Only this second step creates the standing-behind. The analysis works by showing that the unity, when examined, is not found apart from the faces it was drawn from. The ground was never there. It was produced by reifying a useful abstraction.

Dharmakīrti's theory of *apoha*, exclusion, is a helpful companion here. On that account a universal is understood by excluding what it is not, rather than by pointing to a real common essence. Madhyamaka presses further. A commonality taken as a ground has become *svabhāva*, own-nature.

Svabhāva, then, is not located in the content of an experience. Redness, sound and the feeling of presence can be exactly as vivid whether or not they are held as svabhāva. It is a matter of how the appearing is seen: as existing from its own side, independent of conditions, and as the foundation from which other things derive their being.

The same red can be seen in two ways. In one, it is taken as a ground, what is really there and what everything else is measured

against. In the other, it appears, relating to light, eye and attention, and nothing is posited beneath it. The first is svabhāva. The second is dependent origination. The difference lies entirely in the seeing.

This is why the taste of presence cannot be described as a foundation the analysis finally reaches. Appearance seen without a standing-behind is dependent through and through, and its immediacy is that of something relating, not of something standing on its own.

It also explains why the habit is hard to see. The mind has learned, through language, perception and emotion, to treat each vivid appearance as a thing with a fixed character. The habit is so reliable that the designation disappears into what is designated. The inherent framework is not argued for. It is assumed each time the appearance is met. Repeated looking loosens the assumption. Each time the formation is watched, the framework is seen to be added, not found. What was taken as a fact about the world is recognised as a way of seeing it, one that works without needing to be true from its own side.

CHAPTER 16

Non-Dividing Seeing

Analysis answers the dividing habit. It works when there is a habit to reify, and it reaches its end when there is nothing left to examine. The question of this chapter is what remains then.

Cognition seems to work in two ways. The first divides, as the last chapter showed. The second does not divide. It registers what presents without the names, categories and part-whole structure that thought adds. The Buddhist traditions give these modes different names. The first is conceptual construction, *vikalpa*. The second is non-conceptual awareness, *avikalpa*. Dharmakīrti defined direct perception as free of conceptual construction, registering the particular without the name that would make it a thing.

It would be tempting to treat the two as stages, first analysis and then recognition. That reading is mistaken. The dividing mode is the habit that analysis answers. The non-dividing mode is what remains when the habit is no longer operating. Non-dividing seeing is therefore not a second method that completes the analysis, and it is not a stillness reached by effort. It is appearing as it is when no fixing occurs: presented whole, without a before and an after, with designation as the forming itself.

The duck-rabbit makes the point. The drawing can be seen as a duck or as a rabbit. Nothing on the page changes when the aspect switches. The lines are the same, the light is the same, the eye is the same. Yet what is seen changes completely. The duck is not first seen as neutral lines and then labelled a duck. It is seen as a duck, at once, with the designation already in the seeing. When it becomes a rabbit, the change is as vivid as a change of colour.

The same structure is at work every time we read. Look at the word on this line and try to see it only as marks. A literate reader

cannot. The meaning is not decoded after the shapes have been seen. Seeing the shapes is reading them. A trained musician hears a cadence resolve, not a sequence of pitches she must then interpret. Give the same reader a page in an unfamiliar script, and the meaning falls away. What remains is not a bare layer beneath reading. It is seen as writing of some kind, not as cracks in the paper. One seeing-as is replaced by another. Remove the designation and a different designation is found, never an undesignated floor.

The non-dividing seeing of the same appearing is not a second reality. It is the same vivid appearing, without the division into parts and the standing-behind. In reference to the seen, there is only the seen; in reference to the heard, only the heard. Analysis shows that the parts searched for in an object are not there, and that the dividing mind is a formation. Non-conceptual seeing shows the same appearing without the division. Neither needs to be forced, and neither is the final truth of what is seen.

This is the point where the two modes meet. They do not point to different results. One approaches the appearing by dismantling the habit of dividing it. The other sees the appearing as it is once the habit is no longer operating. Both are established by emptiness, and emptiness is not a further thing, but what dependent arising amounts to when it is seen.

. . .

The eight extremes turned over, the criteria of convention, and the two modes of seeing have shown what the analysis of appearance can do. It dismantles the habit of reification. It leaves a seeing that does not divide. What is still unresolved is the fourth assumption: the question of why appearances spring forth at all. Part IV takes up that question, and the traditions that answer it, and asks what the taste of pacified reification is like from inside.

PART IV

Beyond Cause and Effect

CHAPTER 17

The Three Assumptions and the Fourth

The phrase “beyond cause and effect” is one of the most misunderstood in the Dzogchen vocabulary. Read quickly, it sounds like an exception: a realm where causes do not operate, or a ground that produces appearances without being produced itself. A Madhyamaka reader will reasonably ask whether this is simply a smuggled substrate, a producer granted one final exemption from having to justify itself.

This chapter argues that the phrase is not an exception to dependent arising. It names what dependent arising looks like once the habit of reifying has been seen through. The route runs through three assumptions that analysis dismantles, a fourth that survives them, and a mode of seeing that does not divide.

The book frames the problem with a scheme of its own, not one that Madhyamaka presents (see the Note on Method). On this framing, most inquiry into causation rests on three assumptions, usually unstated. The first holds that appearance requires an intrinsic essence, something a thing has from its own side. The second holds that functioning requires an intrinsic causal power, a capacity the cause carries into the effect. The third holds that the coherent alignment of conditions requires a deeper ontological foundation beneath it.

Analysis meets each in turn. Take a chariot. Its wheels, axle and pole are examined, and the chariot is not found in any of them. Take the power of a cause. Look for it in the cause and it dissolves into a designation that depends on the effect it is said to produce. Take the foundation. Look for the ground beneath the conditions and it becomes one more whole to be divided, and its parts are designated too.

Two claims must be held together, and both are stated here before anything is explained.

First, analysis leaves no deeper foundation from which appearance is produced. No essence, no intrinsic power, and no substrate beneath the conditions can be found to do the producing. Every candidate is tested, and each is either found to be another designated whole or is not found at all.

Second, appearances do arise. They appear when certain factors are present and aligned: a wheel, an axle and a pole brought together by a maker's labour; a flame with fuel, air and a wick; an eye, a form and attention meeting. The analysis does not take this away. The chariot is not found in its parts, and it is not found apart from them.

Read side by side, the two points seem to cancel each other. The first seems to deny that anything produces appearance, and the second seems to say that conditions do. Before concluding that one must give way, consider a flame, the book's own illustration rather than an example from the MMK. Fuel, air and heat are brought together, and the flame appears. Remove one and it goes out. The conditions are necessary, and the burning is not separate from their meeting.

But the reader will press at once: does the fuel produce the flame, or does the flame arise from nothing? If the fuel produces it, something must pass from fuel into flame, and the flame has a separate origin. That reading affirms a producer. If nothing produces it, the flame seems to appear from nothing, a groundless event standing alone. That reading denies the conditions and turns the appearance into a self-starting thing. The two answers look like a dilemma: either a producer, or no reason at all.

The dilemma is the conflict, and both of its horns make the same assumption. They take "cause" to name an item that either stands outside the burning and produces it, or is absent. The first point removes the item. The second keeps the conditions. Put together, the question "is there a producer?" searches for something the designation "fuel producing flame" does not contain. The burning is

not a product handed from fuel to flame, and it is not a flame with no reason. It is the alignment, designated as cause when traced in sequence, and designated as a single burning when seen undivided. The question of origin loses its object at the point where the conditions are complete.

Holding the two together forces a choice about what "cause" can mean. Three senses are in play. The first is the intrinsic producer: a cause that exists on its own and delivers an effect from outside itself. MMK 1.1 rejects arising from self, from other, from both, or without cause, and the first claim excludes this sense completely. The second is conditional alignment: one factor among others that, when assembled, lets a result appear. The second claim affirms it. It is valid as a conventional description, and it does real work, telling us which factors to bring together if we want a fire and which to remove if we want it to stop. The third is the designated relatum: "cause" is the element attention picks out when it sequences a process. The web of dependence is real as a web, but its relata are drawn by designation, and the presenting basis is itself one of them, with no web drawn over it.

The two claims do not conflict once the senses are separated. A cause is a designated relatum within a web, and it is nothing over and above its designation. This is why MMK 24.18 can say that dependent origination, being a dependent designation, is itself emptiness, and is the middle way. The designation is not a thin cover over a real producer. It is the whole status of the cause.

So the two points were never rival answers to one question. They are two statements about one appearing. One says nothing outside the alignment produces it. The other says the alignment is what appears. Described in sequence, this is cause and effect. Seen undivided, with no before and no after, there is no sequence and no owner.

The fourth assumption survives these three. It is the most difficult to catch, because it no longer asks what produces appearances. It asks why they spring forth at all, as though the alignment of conditions were still an incomplete answer, still owed

some further and final justification. On this book's reading, which is the author's interpretive step and not a classical claim, this is the last spell. It does not search for essence, or power, or substrate. It searches for permission to stop searching. It mistakes a spontaneous ground for the thing that finally grants that permission.

The "why" question has force only while a producer seems to stand behind appearing, a prior ground for which the question can ask a reason. Seen through, there is no such ground. The question is not answered. It has no object, and so it stops applying. This is the sense in which the answer to "why do they spring forth?" is "no why and because." The phrase does not contradict dependent arising. It marks the point where the question of cause no longer has a referent.

CHAPTER 18

Spontaneous Presence

The Dzogchen term for this appearing is *lhun grub*, spontaneous presence. The word can slide into causelessness, and an uncaused source is exactly the *svabhāva* that Madhyamaka rejects. That is the risk, and the book should name it openly.

The way to keep the two aligned is to separate two questions. The first asks how an appearance comes about. Every appearance has an answer: it arises from causes and conditions, and the analysis of the Middle Way works at that level. The second asks about the way what appears is unfixed. Emptiness is not an intrinsic nature that appearances possess. It is the absence of any fixing, and it is not confined to mind. There is not one phenomenon that has not arisen dependently, and so there is not one phenomenon that is not empty (MMK 24.19).

Spontaneous presence, then, does not name an additional ingredient sitting on top of emptiness. It names the same appearing once every demand for a producer, substrate or ultimate why has been exhausted. Any attempt to divide appearing, including analysis, belongs to dependent arising. When the reifying habit stops, the same appearing is spontaneous presence. Neither is a higher description, and neither grounds the other. What presents is already complete, and it does not wait for construction to become what it is. Both deny production by an essence, and both leave appearance intact.

The phrase “no why or because” is worth returning to. It does not deny causal regularity. Causes and effects hold within conventional truth, and the question “why?” is perfectly usable in ordinary life. What it denies is that the regularity has a ground beneath it, a reason why it is so that is itself uncaused. The question stops

applying there, not because the answer is hidden, but because there was never a ground to ask about.

Two safeguards keep this from becoming a new ground. Emptiness is not a separate reality standing behind phenomena. And emptiness must not become a hidden substrate of emptiness either, because emptiness is itself empty.

Held together, the two claims point to a reading that is easy to miss. Appearance and its conditions do not stand in a hierarchy. The conditions are not a ground that the appearance is built on, and the appearance is not a surface that expresses a deeper condition. Neither is above the other, because neither has a place from which it could rule. What follows is the author's reading, not a classical claim. The arrangement is flat: the chariot's parts and the chariot, a flame and its fuel, a seeing and its object each occur within the same web, without one presiding over the rest.

Yet this flatness has no owner. The question "whose appearance is this?" has a referent only if an appearer stands behind the appearing. The first claim removes the appearer, and the second shows that the appearing does not stop for want of one. So the appearing is not a subject showing its contents. It is self-appearing only in a thin sense. The alignment of conditions is the appearing, shown without a layer or an intermediary, as a flame's light is the burning and not a second thing given off by it.

This is the book's insubstantial reading of self-appearing. "Self" here names only that the appearance is not borrowed from another place. It does not name an entity that owns it. The alignment appears without any self that it belongs to. Two cautions keep the reading honest. The phrase "conditions presenting their own appearances" must not be heard as conditions that are agents, each with an inner viewpoint. A condition is a designated relatum, and its appearing is not a second event added to its being a condition. And "own" is the easiest place for a self to return, so the reading holds only if the appearing is understood as belonging to no one, not as a holder's possession. The MMK's examination of self in chapter 18 tests whether a self can be found apart from the

aggregates, and finds none. The reading takes that result as given and asks only what appearing is once the search has ended.

CHAPTER 19

Two Traditions, One Risk

The two traditions are not in agreement on everything, and their synchronisation has to be argued rather than assumed.

Dzogchen speaks of *rang rig*, self-cognizing awareness. The difficulty is that a nature that is not produced but is the ground of appearances sounds very close to the *svabhāva* that Madhyamaka refuses. Candrakīrti's sixth chapter of the *Madhyamakāvatāra* criticises the self-awareness (*svasaṃvedana*) of cognition, the Yogācāra view of self-knowing mind. The standard counterexample in these debates is the blade that cannot cut itself: a cognition cannot know itself without splitting into a knower and a known. The Buddhist logicians' reply uses the lamp. Dharmakīrti takes a lamp as the model of self-awareness, and Prajñākaragupta argues that a cognition arises with the essence of shining, so that the blade comparison does not apply to it. On this reading self-knowing is not a second act performed on the flow of awareness. It is that flow's luminosity.

Mipham's *Beacon of Certainty*, in John Whitney Pettit's translation and study, defends Dzogchen in the terms of Madhyamaka logic, and it argues with Gelug positions, including Tsongkhapa's eight points of difficulty. Its treatment of the relation between Dzogchen view and Madhyamaka is one of the main sources for the synthesis this book offers, and it should be read in full before the reader accepts or rejects that synthesis.

Other readings of Longchenpa differ. David Higgins's study of the sems and ye shes distinction reads Longchenpa as rejecting self-reflective awareness. The chapter presents this reading, the Dharmakīrtian lamp and the Madhyamaka objection as interpretations to be weighed, not as settled positions.

Longchenpa's own account of the ground is careful. He does not treat the ground as a foundation: it is called a ground only from a relative perspective, and in the true nature of reality it is empty of being one.

Whether the two traditions refer to the same thing is still contested. Some lineages hold that Dzogchen is its own resultant vehicle, not reducible to or guaranteed by Madhyamaka analysis. The claim that the two traditions share a view of appearing and its emptiness is a synthesis, and this book presents it as one. The narrower and more defensible claim is that they agree the substantialist grasp is the problem, and that their methods converge on undoing it.

The two traditions also meet at a shared danger in practice. Dzogchen teachers distinguish suppressing thoughts from their self-release (*rang grol*). Suppression pushes thoughts down, which can create a stillness that becomes one more fixed state. Self-release lets thoughts dissolve when they are not followed or fixed. Madhyamaka makes the same point from its own side. Candrakīrti accepted śamatha as a conventional means that calms the mind, but he held that the decisive step is analysis, which shows that the parts searched for cannot be found. Stillness forced by effort can become a new object of holding.

CHAPTER 20

The Gap and Its Absence

If every act of knowing carries a structure of subject facing object, with a ground behind the appearing, then every taste of presence is already filtered through a gap. Any act of knowing carries the structure with it, so the direct taste cannot be reached by adding one more act on top of the rest.

The tradition's answer is not that a bridge is built across the gap. It is that the gap was never holding anything up. When the standing-behind is seen through, there is no longer a witness positioned apart from what appears, and no ground that appearances must be measured against. What remains is the immediacy of appearing itself.

This is why the experience can be vivid and direct. Vividness here is not intensity added to ordinary perception. It is the absence of the mediation that normally makes perception feel distant. The emptiness that applies to the dull applies equally to the vivid. The immediacy is not a quality that makes appearances more real. It is a quality of how they are not being held at a distance.

Longchenpa's *The Natural Freedom of the Nature of Mind* takes self-release (*rang grol*) as its theme. Seen from the side of thinking, thoughts arise and are not followed, and in not being followed they do not become a wall.

The question that follows is whether this is an achievement or a stopping. If the gap is a construction, its absence is a stopping rather than an accomplishment, and the taste is available wherever the construction is not running. If the gap were inherent, the taste would be impossible, and practice would only demonstrate the gap. Madhyamaka and Dzogchen both take the first view. That means the

book owes an account of why the construction persists so readily, and of what in practice loosens it.

A caution belongs here. “No gap, no ground” can become a new ground: a confident description of non-duality that the reader is invited to possess. The immediacy is better described as something that appears when the standing-behind is not being maintained, not as a state the reader can now be sure of.

CHAPTER 21

The Taste of Pacified Reification

What is it like, from inside, when reification is pacified? The classical formulation is found in the Bahiya sutta, Udāna 1.10. In Ṭhānissaro Bhikkhu's translation it reads: "In reference to the seen, there will be only the seen. In reference to the heard, only the heard." Other translations differ in wording, and the book follows the one named here throughout. The sutta is sometimes read as reducing experience to isolated sense events, or as describing a blank. Neither reading fits.

The formulation names a taste. Seeing is just seeing, and hearing is just hearing. No seer stands behind the seeing, and no hearer behind the hearing. The gap between observer and observed was a designation laid over immediate experience, and it was never found in the experience itself. Once the designation stops, experience has a vividness that is hard to describe. Colours are vivid, sounds are immediate, and thoughts lose their heavy ownership.

This taste is the mark that the reifying habit has been seen through. It is not a higher stage on a path, and it is not an attainment. It is recognised, and the moment one tries to keep it as an accomplishment, the fixing has returned. The witness is a useful case. If the witness is a separate subject standing behind experience, it becomes one more *svabhāva*. Seen without fixing, the seeing is simply vivid, and no witness is posited as doing the seeing.

The same unfixed appearing can be met in two ways. Open seeing is what appears when the habit of fixing is not operating. Contrived seeing is the same appearing met with fixing, so that stillness, vividness and a sense of freedom become objects to hold. The difference lies in the seeing, not in emptiness, and not in a seer

standing behind it. Recognising the difference does not happen by itself. It takes clear knowing, which is itself part of the practice.

The taste is also not a denial of the world. The seen is still seen, the heard still heard. Nothing has been removed from experience. What has been removed is the addition of a viewer and a ground, and with them the sense that experience is happening to someone from somewhere.

CHAPTER 22

Painted Food, Painted Hunger

Zen has an old saying: a painted rice cake does not satisfy hunger. It is a warning that concepts are pictures of food, and that realisation is eating. The monk Xiangyan, famous for his learning, burned his notes after failing to answer his teacher's question. Years later, sweeping a path, he heard a pebble strike a bamboo stalk and woke.

Dōgen, in the *Shōbōgenzō* fascicle *Gabyō*, turns the saying over. In effect he says that there is no remedy for satisfying hunger other than painted rice cakes, and that without painted hunger one never becomes a true person. He is not praising study over practice. He is refusing the picture the saying depends on: a real, unpainted rice cake on one side, and paintings of it, pale and useless, on the other.

Take the next thing you are about to eat, a rice cake if you have one, a piece of bread if you do not, and look for the unpainted one. It appears, first of all, as food. It is not a white, soft, roughly round object that you then recognise as edible. It is already something to eat, already pulling at the hand. Remove that. Remove the name, and the knowing that it is made from rice. Remove the hunger that makes it look good, and the occasions it belongs to: the New Year table, the plate at a temple, the snack at your desk. Remove the farmer and the field, the mill, the steamer, the hand that pounded it. What is left that is the rice cake itself, before any of this painted it?

The search has the shape of the chariot's and the mountain's. Each place you look yields more appearance, designated together with its conditions, and no unpainted cake behind it. To a stone, nothing on the plate is food at all. To an ant, it is a mountain of sugar. The rice cake that is just there, apart from every way of meeting it, is not found.

It would be easy to hear Dōgen as saying that rice cakes are only pictures, that there is nothing but the mind's painting. That is the sticker picture turned inside out. There is no blank canvas under the painting, and no painter standing apart from it. The painting is not a copy of something unpainted, and it is not a fiction laid over nothing. It is how anything is met at all. And the painted cake feeds. Eat it and the hunger goes. Nothing in the analysis touches that. What is removed is only the assumption that, for the cake to really feed you, there must be an unpainted cake doing the feeding underneath.

Dōgen goes one step further, and it is the step that matters most for practice. The hunger is painted too. A hollowness in the stomach, a slight weakness, a thought about lunch, the glance at the clock: hunger is designated together with the food that would end it, the way fuel is designated only as what fire burns. Without food there is no hunger for anything. Without hunger, nothing on the table is food. Neither comes first, and neither is found from its own side. Yet hunger is not less real for that. It gets you up from the desk.

None of this makes Xiangyan wrong to burn his notes. What he burned was not concepts as such, but the use he had made of them: a substitute for seeing, the ceaseless turning of ideas, mental gymnastics performed under the name of inquiry. The cure for that was not a better note. It was the pebble on the bamboo.

But the lesson is not that awakening lies on the far side of all painting, in some unpainted, non-conceptual ground. That reading keeps the two-storey picture and simply moves the practitioner upstairs. The sound of the pebble was painted too: heard as a sound, as a click, as the end of a long search. Realisation did not escape designation. It saw through the demand that there be something unpainted behind it.

The exercise. Take the length of a meal.

1. Before eating, notice how the food appears: already as food, already wanted. Nothing in what follows asks you to see less of this.

2. Look for the unpainted food, apart from its name, your hunger, its history and its use. Go slowly. Notice that each place you look yields more appearance and no food standing behind it.
3. Look at the hunger the same way. Where is it, apart from the food, the stomach, the hour?
4. Then put the looking down and eat.

The point is not to arrive at a feeling of emptiness while chewing. It is to notice that the meal is exactly as satisfying as before. Painted food, painted hunger, painted satisfaction, and nothing missing.

CHAPTER 23

Recognition, Not Effort

Recognition is the central term of Dzogchen practice, and this chapter uses it in a narrower sense than the tradition often does. In Dzogchen, knowledge of the basis comes from recognising it, and recognition is frequently identified with awakening. The argument here does not dispute that recognition is decisive. It disputes only one reading of it: that recognition is a state built up through effort, or a result gained by practice. Freedom is not produced, and practice does not make it. What practice does is undo the habit that obscures it, and recognition is the seeing that the undoing makes possible. The title, Recognition, Not Effort, should be read in that sense.

The natural state is not produced by stopping thought, and it is not achieved by pushing appearances away. Thought is recognised as already empty, already not fixed, and in that recognition it stops fixing.

Recognition is the key term. *Lhun grub* means already complete. It is not produced by effort, and so it is not a state one gets more of by trying harder. The moment one treats effortlessness as an accomplishment, one has made it another fixed object. The word "effortless" needs watching for this reason. It is recognised, and the moment one holds it as a thing to maintain, one has left it.

The same caution applies to negation. The Middle Way warns that those who take emptiness as a view are incurable. A way out that works by negating appearances until nothing is left is still a fixer, now working on a different object. Recognition differs in kind. It does not negate. It sees that appearances are already not fixed. Nothing needs to be done to appearances themselves. What needs

doing is undoing the habit that fixes them, and that undoing is itself a practice.

Madhyamaka draws a distinction that helps here, already met in Chapter 4 as a negation without a thesis and in Chapter 12 as the eight negations. Non-implicative negation denies without installing a replacement. Implicative negation denies and installs a positive ground in its place. Recognition must remain in the first category. If "the nature of each appearance" becomes a positive ground beneath appearances, the disease of reification has returned in a new form.

The traditions differ on how the habit is undone. Gelug describes a graduated path of understanding and meditation that wears the habit down over time. Dzogchen describes a recognition that is not an accomplishment and happens at once. That is a difference in method, not in whether freedom is made.

The path also reorganises practice around three recognitions. Conditions are what work: anger is not a thing with its own nature, and it reconfigures when the attention, the interpretation and the circumstances change. Appearing is open because it is dependent, so practice works because nothing is fixed. And there is nothing to hold, and no one apart from the holding. The practitioner is designated on the practising and is not found apart from it.

Openness is how unfixed appearing is seen when fixing is not operating, and contrivance is the same appearing seen with fixing. Practice works because nothing is fixed, and what changes is the seeing.

The trap remains. Openness, non-holding and emptiness can quietly become the new things held. They can become a state to reach, an attitude to maintain, a view to defend. Openness, too, is empty. It is not something one has. It is the absence of what one was holding.

The question of how to write about this is itself part of the practice. A prompt that is composed from unresolved grasping tends to produce a reader who grasps at the prompt. The most a text can do is point, and then get out of the way.

The book ends where it began. The observer that seemed to stand behind experience has not been found. Vividness has been seen without a viewer. The substrates, the logics and the modes of seeing have each been looked at and found to be designations that work and cannot stand on their own. Undoing the habit that fixed them requires clear knowing, and that clear knowing is the practice that remains.

. . .

The book has moved from the observer to the taste of pacified reification. The appendices collect the verse text, the glossary, the Beginner's Companion, and the references, so that the narrative can stand on its own while the reader who wants the sources has them in one place.

Appendices

APPENDIX A

The Verse Text, an Index

The chapters of this book draw on the following verses of the *Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*. The full translation, with the Sanskrit, appears in the companion volume. Use this index to find the passage a chapter refers to. Verse numbers follow Garfield (1995) and Siderits and Katsura (2013), which number the first verse of chapter 1 after the homage as 1.1. Editions that count the dedicatory verses number chapter 1 two verses higher.

Verse	Subject	Chapter(s)
Homage	Dependent arising without arising or ceasing, without coming or going; the quieting of elaborations as peace	12
1.1	Refutation of arising from self, other, both, and without cause; non-arising	12, 17
1.5	Conditions and what arises from them. No MMK 1.5 salt-and-water passage has been found; the Chapter 8 example is the book's own illustration.	8
2	Motion; walker and walking designated together	11
2.18–21	The goer is neither identical with nor different from the going; changer and change	11
3	Seeing, seer and seen; no seeing by its own nature; the chain of dependence	1, 16
5	Space and its characteristic; the analysis of characterised and characteriser	5
7	The conditioned: arising, abiding and ceasing	12
10.1	Fire and fuel: neither one nor other	4
13.8	Those who take emptiness as a view are incurable	18, 23
14	Seer, seeing and seen; the analysis of contact and otherness	1, 16
15.2	Own-nature (svabhāva) is defined as non-contingent and not dependent on anything other than itself.	4, 12

Verse	Subject	Chapter(s)
15.10–11	Existence and non-existence of a thing standing on its own; permanence and annihilation	4, 12
18.5	Proliferation ceases in emptiness	14
18.10	Neither identical with nor different from what it depends on	12
19	Time; the anaesthesia and the river of time	4, 10
24.8–10	Conventional and ultimate truth; neither is a lower stage	13
24.14	For whom emptiness is possible, everything is possible (the verb yujyate: “fits”)	8
24.16–20	Practice works because nothing is fixed	23
24.18	Dependent co-arising is emptiness; that, being dependent designation, is the middle way	14, 17
24.19	There is not one phenomenon that has not arisen dependently, and so none that is not empty	14, 18
27	Continuity without persistence; neither identical nor wholly different	9

APPENDIX B

Glossary

Abandonment. The ending of the afflictions, possible only because they are empty.

Afflictions (*kleśa*). States that disturb the mind and drive suffering: craving, aversion and delusion.

Apoha. Exclusion. On Dharmakīrti's account, a universal is understood by excluding what it is not, rather than by pointing to a common essence.

Avikalpa. Non-conceptual awareness: registering what presents without the names, categories and part-whole structure that thought adds.

Basis (*gzhi*). In Dzogchen, the primordial state of any sentient being, from which path and fruition are said to unfold; knowledge of it is *rigpa*. Longchenpa treats it as a ground only from a relative perspective, empty of being a ground in the true nature of reality. This book reads the basis as the emptiness of appearing, not as a ground behind appearances. See the Note on Method. *Source: the Wikipedia "Ground (Dzogchen)" article, summarising Longchenpa.*

Clarity (*gsal ba*). In Dzogchen, the clear nature (*rang bzhin*) of the basis, one of its three aspects together with its empty essence (*ngo bo*) and its unobstructed compassion (*thugs rje*). In this book, the knowing clarity of appearing itself, not a substance behind it. See Luminosity. *Source for the three aspects: Rangjung Yeshe Wiki, "primordial ground" and "ngo bo rang bzhin thugs rje gsum", where Longchenpa's three factors appear as an empty essence, a clear nature and an unobstructed radiance of compassion. The book's own gloss is stated as a gloss.*

Conditions (*pratyaya*). What something arises in dependence on. The Abhidharma listed four kinds.

Contrivance (in this book). The same unfixed appearing, met with the habit of fixing still operating. Its counterpart is openness. This is a term of the book's own, not a standard Dzogchen term.

Conventional truth (*saṃvṛti-satya*). The level of valid designation, in which causal explanation and the words "why" and "because" are usable.

Dependent arising (*pratītyasamutpāda*). Things appear only in dependence on other things, and on the way they are picked out.

Dependent designation. Things are named and known in dependence on the conditions and the naming itself. Dependent designation is not a compromise between existence and non-existence.

Dharmatā (*chos nyid*). In the standard sources, the true nature of phenomena, often glossed as the intrinsic nature (*svabhāva*) of dharmas, which is constant and transcends discrimination. This book uses "nature" for the way things are, when they are not reified, in a narrower sense than that gloss. It avoids the term for emptiness itself. The difference is stated where the term is first used.

Elaboration (*prapañca*). The mind's spinning-out of "is" and "is not" around something it takes to be there.

Eight extremes. Arising and ceasing, permanence and annihilation, coming and going, identity and difference.

Emptiness (*śūnyatā*, *stong pa nyid*). The lack of intrinsic nature. Not a separate reality behind phenomena, and not itself a hidden substrate. Emptiness has no intrinsic nature of its own, and this book does not call it open, closed or luminous in itself.

Implicative and non-implicative negation. Non-implicative negation (*prasajya-pratiṣedha*) denies without installing a

replacement. Implicative negation (*paryudāsa*) denies and installs a positive ground in its place.

Lhun grub. Spontaneous presence. What dependent arising looks like once no producer is sought. Not an uncaused ground. In Higgins's account (via KMaps), spontaneous presence is the form in which the basic openness of awareness surges forth as luminosity. The book does not read this as an awareness from which luminosity issues; luminosity is the clarity of appearing itself.

Luminosity (*od gsal*). In Dzogchen, a term that is categorised under the clarity aspect of the nature of mind, and related to *lhun grub*. In this book, the knowing clarity of appearance, not a substance behind it. Rangjung Yeshe gives *stong pa'i 'od gsal* as "empty luminosity" and "the luminosity of emptiness." The book uses the first sense only: luminosity is empty, and emptiness has no luminosity of its own (see Emptiness). See Clarity.

Non-arising (*anutpāda*). No arising found from a thing's own side. This is not the same as no causes.

Openness (in this book). The way unfixed appearing meets when it is seen without fixing. It is not a property of emptiness or of the basis, and it does not explain why appearing occurs. Its counterpart is contrivance. This is a departure from the sources. In the sources, openness appears as a characterisation of the ground and of awareness: *rig stong* (cognitive intensity and openness) and *gsal stong* (luminosity and openness, or the unity of clarity and openness), both linked to *lhun grub*. The book's usage is narrower. *Confirmed: Higgins's usage via KMaps; Rangjung Yeshe for gsal stong.*

Own-nature (*svabhāva*). A nature a thing would have from its own side, apart from everything else. Defined in MMK 15.2 as non-contingent and not dependent on anything other than itself. Madhyamaka argues that nothing has it, and that emptiness is not one either. Distinguish from nature as the way things are

(dharmatā). The Tibetan *rang bzhin* is used for both, and in Dzogchen also for the ultimate nature, unaltered because the basis is spontaneously accomplished. The book distinguishes these by context.

Primordial purity (*ka dag*). The Dzogchen description of the basis as pure from the beginning, and a way of signifying emptiness. In this book, read as the unfixed character of appearing, not as an uncaused source. *Confirmed: Higgins (via KMaps) gives "a term signifying primordial purity as a way of signifying emptiness," unique to rNying ma tantric literature. Namkhai Norbu describes the basis as "uncreated, ever pure, and self-perfected, not something that has to be constructed," which supports "unproduced" in this sense. The Buddha-Nature site glosses it as the empty nature of phenomena, and Tshig mdzod chen mo defines it as pure from the beginning, free from stain.*

Rang grol. Self-release: thought dissolves when it is not followed or fixed. The term is standard in Dzogchen and Mahāmudrā (Wikipedia, "Dzogchen"; Studybuddhism glossary).

Rang rig. Self-cognizing awareness (Sanskrit *svasaṃvitti*). The Dzogchen position on it is debated: Mipham's *Beacon of Certainty* (Pettit 1999) defends Dzogchen in Madhyamaka terms, and Higgins (2013) reads Longchenpa as rejecting self-reflective awareness. Chapter 19 presents these readings and the Madhyamaka objection.

Recognition (*ngo shes*; *rang ngo shes* for self-recognition). In Dzogchen, the central term of the path. Knowledge of the basis (*rigpa*) comes from recognising it, and recognition is often identified with awakening: the recognition of the basis is "awakening" in the Dzogchen sources as summarised by Wikipedia. The book does not dispute that recognition is decisive. Its chapter title, "Recognition, Not Effort" (Chapter 23), means only that recognition is not produced by effort or accumulated as a state. See the Note on Method, fourth departure.

Reification. Taking an abstraction, or an appearance, to exist as a thing in its own right, standing beneath the particulars.

Rigpa (*rig pa*). In Dzogchen, the knowledge of the basis, and the pristine awareness that is the basis itself. The book does not take awareness as a basis; see the Note on Method. Its opposite is *ma rigpa*, ignorance, the failure to recognise the basis. Sanskrit *vidyā* ("knowledge"). The book's "knowing clarity" is a gloss on this, not a translation. Ācārya Malcolm Smith translates rigpa as *vidyā*, prefers to leave it untranslated, and holds that rendering it as "awareness" is wrong (quoted in his DharmaWheel posts and the Wisdom Podcast). *Confirmed by Wikipedia's Rigpa article: "knowledge of the ground," opposite ma rigpa.*

Svalakṣaṇa. The particular, what characterises itself alone, in Dignāga's and Dharmakīrti's epistemology. Candrakīrti's first chapter answers a view closely resembling Dignāga's (Arnold 2003, "Candrakīrti on Dignāga on Svalakṣaṇas," *JIABS*). See Chapter 5.

Ultimate truth (*paramārtha-satya*). Not a higher world, but the emptiness of the conventional one.

Unobstructed (*ma 'gags pa*). Nothing blocks the display, and there is no store behind it from which the display comes. Not that something lasts for ever.

Vikalpa. Conceptual construction: the mode of mind that divides, names and asks which part carries identity.

APPENDIX C

The Beginner's Companion, in Eleven Rounds

The Beginner's Companion is this book's own step-by-step path, in eleven rounds. The narrative chapters carry the argument, and the rounds give a reader who wants to practise a way through it, in the order of the chapters. Each round names the chapters it supports.

- **Round 1: The observer.** Look for the witness behind seeing and hearing. Chapters 1 and 2.
- **Round 2: Vividness without a viewer.** Notice that experience is vivid without a holder. Chapter 2.
- **Round 3: The chariot and the parts.** Apply the chariot to the observer and to objects. Chapters 1 and 14.
- **Round 4: Dependence and designation.** The Dharmakīrti and Candrakīrti exchange, with the rope and snake. Chapters 5 and 6.
- **Round 5: The Given and its alternatives.** The two-storey picture, the Given, and conceptual all the way down. Chapters 5, 6 and 15.
- **Round 6: Energy, potentiality and continuity.** Test each candidate for a carrier. Chapters 7, 8 and 9.
- **Round 7: Change without a changer.** Look for the changer apart from the change. Chapter 11.
- **Round 8: The eight extremes.** Apply each extreme to a single object. Chapter 12.
- **Round 9: Analysis and seeing.** Use the dividing mind against itself, then rest in non-dividing seeing. Chapters 14 and 16.
- **Round 10: The taste.** Notice seen as just seen, heard as just heard. Chapter 21.

- **Round 11: The meal.** The painted food and painted hunger exercise. Chapter 22.

APPENDIX D

References

Buddhist sources

Dharmakīrti. *Nyāyabindu*, with Dharmottara's commentary. Translated by F. Th. Stcherbatsky in *Buddhist Logic*, vol. II. Bibliotheca Buddhica 26. Leningrad: Academy of Sciences of the USSR, 1930; Dover reprint, New York, 1962. The definition of perception as free from conceptual construction is in the Nyāyabindu literature; Dignāga's formula is *pratyakṣaṃ kalpanāpoḍhaṃ*, and Dharmakīrti adds "non-erroneous."

Dignāga. *Pramāṇasamuccaya*, chapter 1. Translated by Masaaki Hattori, *Dignāga, On Perception, being the Pratyakṣapariccheda of Dignāga's Pramāṇasamuccaya*. Harvard Oriental Series 47. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1968.

Dōgen. *Genjōkōan*. Translated by Paul Jaffe in Hakuun Yasutani, *Flowers Fall: A Commentary on Zen Master Dōgen's Genjōkōan*. Boston: Shambhala, 1996. The Jaffe wording of the firewood-and-ash passage is as shown on the Terebess Zen Literature page for the Genjōkōan: https://terebess.hu/zen/dogen/KS-Genjo.html.

Dōgen. "Painting of a Rice Cake" (*Gabyō*). Translated by Kazuaki Tanahashi and Dan Welch. In *Moon in a Dewdrop: Writings of Zen Master Dōgen*, edited by Kazuaki Tanahashi. San Francisco: North Point Press, 1985. Chapter 22 paraphrases the fascicle and does not quote it.

Garfield, Jay L. *The Fundamental Wisdom of the Middle Way: Nāgārjuna's Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*. New York: Oxford University Press, 1995. (MMK 24.18 translation; verse numbering in Appendix A.)

Longchenpa. *The Natural Freedom of the Nature of Mind* (*Sems nyid rang grol*). Translated by Herbert V. Guenther as "The Natural Freedom of Mind," *Crystal Mirror* IV (Berkeley: Dharma Publishing, 1975); and by Tulku Thondup as "Naturally Liberated Mind, the Great Perfection," in *The Practice of Dzogchen* (Ithaca: Snow Lion, 1989). Cited in Chapter 20 for its theme.

Milindapañha. The lamp image of Nāgasena (Book II). Translated by T. W. Rhys Davids, *The Questions of King Milinda*, Part I. Sacred Books of the East 35. Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1890.

Mipham. *Mipham's Beacon of Certainty: Illuminating the View of Dzogchen, the Great Perfection*. Translated and introduced by John Whitney Pettit. Studies in Indian and Tibetan Buddhism. Boston: Wisdom Publications, 1999.

Robinson, Richard H. *Early Mādhyamika in India and China*. Madison: University of Wisconsin Press, 1967. (MMK 24.18 translation.)

Siderits, Mark, and Shōryū Katsura. *Nāgārjuna's Middle Way: Mūlamadhyamakakārikā*. Classics of Indian Buddhism. Boston: Wisdom Publications, 2013. (MMK 24.18 translation; verse numbering in Appendix A.)

Sprung, Mervyn, trans., with T. R. V. Murti and U. S. Vyas. *Lucid Exposition of the Middle Way: The Essential Chapters from the Prasannapadā of Candrakīrti*. London and Henley: Routledge & Kegan Paul, 1979. (Also issued by Prajñā Press, Boulder, 1979.) Source of the MMK 24.18 rendering cited in Chapter 14.

Tsongkhapa. *Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path* (*Lam rim chen mo*), special-insight section (*Lhag mthong chen mo*, Great Exposition of Special Insight). Translated by the Lamrim Chenmo Translation Committee, *The Great Treatise on the Stages of the Path to Enlightenment*, vol. 3, edited by Joshua W. C. Cutler and Guy Newland. Ithaca: Snow Lion, 2002. Source of the three criteria for conventional existence (Chapter 13).

Udāna 1.10, the Bahiya sutta. Translated by Ṭhānissaro Bhikkhu. Access to Insight: https://www.accesstoinsight.org/tipitaka/kn/ud/ud.1.10.than.html. Chapters 2 and 21 quote this translation.

Dzogchen and Madhyamaka secondary sources consulted for the glossary

"Ground (Dzogchen)." Wikipedia. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ground_(Dzogchen). Source for the basis, Longchenpa's account of the ground as a ground only from a relative perspective, the description of ka dag, and Namkhai Norbu's "uncreated" description.

"Dzogchen." Wikipedia. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Dzogchen. Source for self-release (rang grol).

"Rigpa." Wikipedia. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Rigpa. Source for rigpa as knowledge of the ground, the opposite ma rigpa, vidyā, and rig stong.

"Svabhava." Wikipedia. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Svabhava. Source for the Tibetan rang bzhin in both senses.

"Automatic release." Study Buddhism glossary. https://studybuddhism.com/en/glossary/automatic-release. Source for rang grol.

"Dharmatā." Tsadra Commons. https://commons.tsadra.org/index.php/Dharmat%C4%81. Source for the standard glosses of chos nyid.

"Ka dag." Buddha-Nature Key Terms, Tsadra. https://buddhanature.tsadra.org/index.php/Ka_dag. Source for the gloss of ka dag as the empty nature of phenomena.

"Pratītyasamutpāda." Bodhicitta Key Terms, Tsadra. Source for the MMK 24.19 wording.

"Primordial ground" and "ngo bo rang bzhin thugs rje gsum." Rangjung Yeshe Wiki. https://rywiki.tsadra.org/index.php/primordial_ground and https://rywiki.tsadra.org/index.php/ngo_bo_rang_bzhin_thugs_rje_gsum. Source for the three aspects of the basis (essence, nature, compassion).

"Gsal stong" and "stong pa'i 'od gsal." Rangjung Yeshe Wiki (RYI Dictionary). https://rywiki.tsadra.org/index.php/gsal_stong and https://rywiki.tsadra.org/index.php/stong_pa%27i_%27od_gsal. Sources for the openness and luminosity glosses.

Higgins, David. Entries in the *Lexicon of Tibetan Buddhist Topics and Terminology*, Tibetan and Himalayan Library (KMaps, University of Virginia), including ka dag (https://terms.kmaps.virginia.edu/features/260). Source for "Higgins (via KMaps)" in the glossary entries Lhun grub, Openness and Primordial purity.

Higgins, David. *The Philosophical Foundations of Classical rDzogs chen in Tibet: Investigating the Distinction between Dualistic Mind (sems) and Primordial Knowing (ye shes)*. Wiener Studien zur Tibetologie und Buddhismuskunde 78. Vienna: Arbeitskreis für Tibetische und Buddhistische Studien, Universität Wien, 2013. Based on the author's doctoral thesis, Université de Lausanne, 2012.

Malcolm Smith (Ācārya). DharmaWheel forum posts on the translation of rigpa; and the Wisdom Podcast interview, *The Dzogchen Aural Lineage* (episode 205).

Kobayashi, Hisayasu. 「灯火の喩え――プラジュニャーカラグプタの自己認識理論――」 (The Lamp as an Example for Self-Awareness: Prajñākaragupta's Theory). *Indogaku Bukkyōgaku Kenkyū* (Journal of Indian and Buddhist Studies) 70, no. 2 (2022). https://doi.org/10.4259/ibk.70.2_926.

Arnold, Dan. "Candrakīrti on Dignāga on Svalakṣaṇas." *Journal of the International Association of Buddhist Studies* 26, no. 1 (2003): 139–174. https://journals.ub.uni-heidelberg.de/index.php/jiabs/article/download/8934/2827.

MacDonald, Anne. "The Madhyamakāvatāra's Critique of Yogācāra." Lecture, Khyentse Center for Tibetan Buddhist Textual Scholarship, Universität Hamburg, 12 January 2022. Source for Candrakīrti's critique of svasaṃvedana in Madhyamakāvatāra ch. 6. https://www.kc-tbts.uni-hamburg.de/events/2022-01-12-macdonald.html.

Philosophical and scientific sources

Dreyfus, Hubert L. "Overcoming the Myth of the Mental: How Philosophers Can Profit from the Phenomenology of Everyday Expertise." *Proceedings and Addresses of the American Philosophical Association* 79, no. 2 (2005): 47–65.

Feynman, Richard P., Robert B. Leighton, and Matthew Sands. *The Feynman Lectures on Physics*, vol. 1, chapter 4, "Conservation of Energy." Reading, MA: Addison-Wesley, 1963.

Kosmann-Schwarzbach, Yvette. *The Noether Theorems: Invariance and Conservation Laws in the Twentieth Century*. Translated by Bertram E. Schwarzbach. New York: Springer, 2011. Includes the English translation of Noether's paper.

Locke, John. *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding* (1690), Book II, chapter 8 (primary and secondary qualities). Edited by Peter H. Nidditch. Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1975.

Lakoff, George, and Mark Johnson. *Metaphors We Live By*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1980.

McDowell, John. *Mind and World*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1994.

McDowell, John. “What Myth?” *Inquiry* 50, no. 4 (2007): 338–351.

Newton, Isaac. *The Principia: Mathematical Principles of Natural Philosophy* (1687), Scholium to the Definitions. Translated by I. Bernard Cohen and Anne Whitman. Berkeley: University of California Press, 1999.

Noether, Emmy. “Invariante Variationsprobleme.” *Nachrichten von der Gesellschaft der Wissenschaften zu Göttingen, Mathematisch-Physikalische Klasse* (1918): 235–257.

Núñez, Rafael E., and Eve Sweetser. “With the Future Behind Them: Convergent Evidence from Aymara Language and Gesture in the Crosslinguistic Comparison of Spatial Construals of Time.” *Cognitive Science* 30, no. 3 (2006): 401–450. https://doi.org/10.1207/s15516709cog0000_62.

Sellars, Wilfrid. “Empiricism and the Philosophy of Mind.” In *The Foundations of Science and the Concepts of Psychology and Psychoanalysis*, edited by Herbert Feigl and Michael Scriven, 253–329. Minnesota Studies in the Philosophy of Science 1. Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press, 1956.